

DELHI If the Indian President, like his US counterpart, was to be elected by the country's voters, it would have been difficult to find a man—or a woman—who would have even dreamt of taking on Abdul Kalam, arguably the most popular President India has ever had. With just two weeks of his term left, Kalam is preparing to leave the imposing Rashtrapati Bhavan on Raisina Hill—the largest presidential palace in the world—as quietly as he had occupied it in July 2002. And without any ill will or rancour.

Last week, Kalam cleared a list of lunches and dinners that he intends to host in his final days in the office. He has already sent out a letter to the prime minister and the Union Cabinet thanking them for their cooperation and invited them over for dinner on July 20, a day after the presi-

Gag and Baggage



HELLO, GOODBYE: Patil (left) with Kalam

dential polls. Next week, he will be hosting parties for the many who served him during his tenure—from ADCs and personal staff right down to the gardeners.

Kalam has turned down suggestions from officers in charge of the transition to requisition half a dozen military trucks to carry his personal belongings, saying he has just about two

dozen bags, most of them containing books.

Rashtrapati Bhavan sources said in the past presidents demitting office have requisitioned even eight to 10 trucks to carry belongings, most of them gifts received during the presidency. Kalam has decided to deposit all his gifts and souvenirs in the Rashtrapati Bhavan *toshakhana* (strong room). A bachelor, Kalam

used just three rooms in the imposing 340-room complex. While he intends to pursue his career as a scientist, Kalam is also said to have accepted a request from Bihar Chief Minister Nitish Kumar to be a visiting professor at the Nalanda University.

Meanwhile, the UPA-Left candidate Pratibha Patil shows no signs of being embroiled in one of the dirtiest presidential elections in history and is said to be making preparations to move in. With the Congress placing an unofficial gag on the now famous Patilisms, Patil may well shake off the muck and make it to the house on the hill where she is expected to be joined by about eight family members for whom 10 rooms are being readied. Rashtrapati Bhavan sources say some of her relatives have visited the place for an assessment of the changes required. ■

THE BUZZ OF THE WEEK

Private airline operators may soon be popping open the bubbly. The Empowered Group of Ministers is expected to grant licences for international flights to all three-year old airlines, down from the current stipulation of five years.

VOICES



“If among a billion people, you cannot think of an Indian to lead the country, then that kind of a party is unpatriotic and untouchable in my perception.”

J. Jayalalithaa, AIADMK chief

“We are not beggars. We are not going to go begging to the CPI(M). They are hypocrites; they say something in Delhi and do something else in Bengal.”

Mamata Banerjee, Trinamool Congress chief

“We don’t want to differentiate multinationals from Indian corporates; both are bad for Kerala. We really don’t want them here at all.”

C. Divakaran, CPI leader

“The term ‘Bollywood’ was used by the western press to mock at us. And it is just an indication of our own idiocy that we still use it.”

Naseeruddin Shah, actor

“I really don’t blame my critics because they have given me all the awards. They said I am a nasal singer and I have accepted it.”

Himesh Reshammiya, singer-musician-actor

